RIGHT TO BEAR ARMS

A One-Shot for 5 Players, Level 6

A village needs its magic weapons.
A genius owlbear claims them as legal property.
A raiding party arrives at sundown.
The law is unclear.
The claws are not.

Party Size	5 players
Party Level	6
Difficulty	Hard — they should sweat
Runtime	5–7 hours, one session
Setting	Brindlebarrow, edge of the Western Woods
Core Question	At what number of thoughts does a creature become a person?

DM Brief — Read This First

This is a moral-dilemma session disguised as a heist. Play the comedy on the surface; let the truth surface slowly underneath.

The premise the players hear

An owlbear got into the village armory, stole every magic item Brindlebarrow owned, and dragged them into its cave. The village hired the party to get them back. There is a hostile warband approaching by nightfall and the village cannot defend itself without those items.

The truth they will discover

- The owlbear is now intelligent — the Mantle of Intellect awakened after it came from a dead scholar-adventurer and settled across the owlbear's shoulders in the lair.
- It did not steal the items out of greed. It is guarding three eggs.
- The raiders aren't just coming for the village. They know the eggs exist.
- The owlbear correctly assessed that Brindlebarrow's armory was indefensible and took command.
- Grubbleclaw is not the villain. There is no villain. There is a coming attack and three competing claims to the same defensive weapons.

How Grubbleclaw Got the Mantle

Three months ago, a scholar-adventurer named Ilyra Voss entered the Western Woods wearing a silver-violet Mantle of Intellect. Her party was searching for old ruins beyond the ridge and ignored local warnings about owlbear territory.

The owlbear was not yet intelligent. It attacked as a nesting predator when Ilyra and her companions crossed the nest-path with fire and steel. Ilyra died near the lair approach. The owlbear dragged her cloak, pack, books, and bright metal clasps into the den as nesting material.

The mantle awakened when it settled across the owlbear's shoulders. First came memory. Then language. Then strategy. Then the terrible realization that three eggs were hidden in a forest now being watched by raiders.

The village did not create Grubbleclaw. The village merely became the nearest unsecured armory.

Player-facing short answer: villagers know only that Ilyra Voss disappeared in the Western Woods months ago wearing a silver-violet mantle. Grubbleclaw can reveal the full truth if asked respectfully.

New DM Fast Start — Read This Before the Session

You do not need to memorize this packet. Your job is to describe the situation clearly, ask what the players do, and make a fair ruling when the answer is uncertain. Use the adventure notes as support—not as a script.

When this happens	Do this
The players try something obvious	If success is certain and failure would not be interesting, do not call for a roll. Let it happen and move the story forward.
The outcome is uncertain	Call for a d20 test only when success and failure both matter. For an improvised task, DC 10 is easy, 15 is medium, and 20 is hard.
A required clue is at risk	Do not hide the only path forward behind one die roll. Give the core clue when the players search the right place; a successful check adds detail, speed, leverage, or certainty.
A roll fails	Fail forward. Charge a cost: time, damage, position, trust, noise, lost resources, or incomplete information. Do not dead-end the adventure.
You forget a rule	Make a fair temporary ruling in about 30 seconds, write down the question, and verify it after the session. Momentum is more valuable than perfect recall.
An NPC scene feels hard	Use three things already in this packet: what the NPC wants, what the NPC knows, and the opening line. That is enough to roleplay the scene.
Combat starts dragging	Use the listed tactics and morale. Enemies can flee, surrender, bargain, or change objectives. Do not add extra complexity just because the fight feels simple.
The group is running late	Trim repeated investigation beats and shorten low-stakes combat. Protect the egg reveal, the 45–60 minute Grubbleclaw negotiation, and the final village decision.

You are not the party's opponent.
Present honest problems, play NPCs and enemies according to their motives, and let smart player choices matter—even when those choices bypass something you prepared.

Before the players sit down

Read the DM Brief, the Grubbleclaw negotiation, the Final Defense, and the Endings. Keep the final cheat sheet beside you. Have Old Cobb's map ready to hand out. Decide where the group can take a break, and tell the players they can ask for a pause or content change at any time.

Pacing target

5–7 hours total. The owlbear conversation in the negotiation chamber is the centerpiece — give it 45–60 minutes of real table time. Everything else exists to set up or pay off that scene.

Three clocks running at once

Keep all three visible on a notecard at the table. Players win when they balance them.

Clock	What ticks it	Failure state
Recover items	Each item still in the lair at nightfall	Village defense collapses
Survive the lair	Hostile encounters with Grubbleclaw	TPK or fled empty-handed
Prepare the village	Time spent organizing / training before dusk	Defense Points start low

The Hidden Subplot — Someone in the Village Is Talking

The raiders know too much. They know Brindlebarrow had a magic cache. They know the armory layout. They know the southern gate is the weak point. Someone has been feeding them information.

The Red Herring — Brother Halven (innocent)

Halven looks guilty. He fell asleep at the armory the night of the theft. He has been jittery, evasive, taking unexplained trips out of the village. He owns one of the two sets of armory keys. He drinks. He has gambling debts.

Halven is not the traitor. His shameful secrets are mundane: he was visiting a dying mother in the next village (the trips), he sleeps badly because of guilt (the jitters), and the gambling debts are real but not raider-relevant. He fell asleep on watch because he is an old, tired priest who failed his duty. He knows it. He cannot say it.

Lean into him as a suspect. Let the players accuse him. Then twist the knife.

The Actual Traitor — Watch Captain Edra Vell (guilty)

Edra is the village watch captain. Capable. Popular. The party's natural tactical ally. She will help them prep defenses, train militia, and plan choke points. She is also the one feeding the raiders intel.

Three months ago, raiders attacked a logging camp where her younger brother Tomas was working. He was taken. A week later, she received a letter wrapped around his pinky ring: "Tell us when and where, and he lives. Resist, and he dies." She has been complying ever since.

She does not know Tomas died in the original raid. The Red Tusk shaman has been blackmailing her with a corpse's ring for three months.

> **Why this lands hard**
>
> Edra is not evil. She is a competent leader trying to save someone she loves, doing terrible things on bad information. The party will trust her. When they figure it out, the question is not 'do we kill the traitor' but 'what do you do with someone who betrayed you for a brother who was already dead.' That is the second moral question of the session, layered under the first.

Clue placement (woven into existing scenes)

- Armory: Investigation DC 16 — there are TWO sets of footprints leading away from the armory. One owlbear. One human-sized, with a boot tread matching the village watch.
- Bess Tinder (new NPC) drops the line: 'Edra used to laugh more. Something's eating her.'
- Halven, if defended, will mention seeing Edra leaving the village at odd hours — he assumed she was patrolling.
- Skitters, if questioned about raider intel: 'The iron-haired one with the scar told us where to hit. South gate.' (Edra has iron-grey hair and a scar across her left cheek.)
- Grubbleclaw's tactical map in Area 3 shows one perfect arrow at the south gate. Investigation DC 14: 'Whoever drew this knew the village from the inside.'
- During final battle: Edra falls back at a critical moment, leaving the southern flank open. Insight DC 13 to spot the deliberate hesitation.

Players who skip every clue still get the reveal during the battle when she makes her move. No path locks them out of the truth.

Session Threat Clock

Use these as soft beats, not hard timers. If players linger somewhere productive, let them. If they stall, the next beat fires whether they're ready or not.

Time of day	Beat	Use this to push them
Morning	Arrive in Brindlebarrow. Investigation of armory.	Show the villagers boarding windows.
Late morning	Track owlbear to forest.	Hunters report tracks going deep.
Midday	Forest approach — warning signs, traps, captured scout.	Skitters reveals raiders arrive at dusk.
Afternoon	Reach the lair. First contact.	Distant horn blast from the south.
Late afternoon	Negotiation chamber. The eggs.	Smoke on the horizon — raider scouts spotted.
Dusk	Return to village. Final prep.	Drums start in the woods.
Night	Raiders attack. Two-front battle.	Roll initiative.

If the party splits or backtracks

Don't punish it — they will. The egg-raid strike team only triggers once the main raid begins. The owlbear will not pursue them out of its lair unless directly attacked first.

Act 1 — Brindlebarrow

Arrival

The village smells like wet hay and panic. Three men are nailing boards across the chapel windows even though the sun is barely up. A goat watches you from a roof. A woman in a flour-dusted apron strides over before your boots have finished sinking into the mud.

"You're the help. Good. We've got until nightfall and the armory's empty. Follow me."

Key NPCs

Mayor Tessa Wicker					
Role Village leader. Practical, exhausted, terrified. **Wants** The items back. Doesn't care how. **Will not** Negotiate with a monster, even if it can talk.					
STR	**DEX**	**CON**	**INT**	**WIS**	**CHA**

10 (+0)	11 (+0)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)

Roleplay note. Crosses her arms when she lies. She is lying about how short-staffed the watch really is — she's afraid the party will think the village is worthless.

Secret (not the traitor). Her husband died in last winter's fever. She has been running the village alone for eight months and is one bad day from breaking. She trusts Edra completely — Edra is her cousin.

Opening line. "You're the help. Good. We've got until nightfall and the armory's empty. Follow me."

When asked about the owlbear. "I don't care if the beast can read poetry now. It has our weapons, and something worse is coming."

When asked about her people. "Forty-three souls. Thirty-eight if you don't count the children. Twenty-six if you don't count the elderly. So: twenty-six souls, and seven of them can hold a spear without dropping it."

If pressed on the missing items. "Yes, we had magic. No, we shouldn't have. A village this size with a Wand of Web on a shelf is asking for exactly this kind of trouble. I know. I know."

When the betrayal is revealed. "...Edra? My Edra?" (Long silence. Then, harder than she's spoken all session:) "Bring her to me."

Brother Halven (the red herring)

Role Village priest. Keeper of the old armory. The obvious suspect.

Wants Forgiveness. He fell asleep. He knows he fell asleep.

Knows The owlbear behaved strangely — picked the lock, reorganized the shelves.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	9 (-1)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)

Why he looks guilty. Jittery. Evasive about his recent absences. Holds one of two armory keys. Drinks. Has gambling debts the village gossips about. Will not meet anyone's eyes for long.

Why he isn't. His 'mysterious trips' are to the next village to sit with his dying mother. His 'evasiveness' is shame about falling asleep on watch. His debts are real but tiny — he owes the tavern eleven silver. The party will accuse him. Let them. He will weep, not resist.

Opening line. "It did not smash the lock. It picked the lock. Then it reorganized the armory by tactical usefulness."

When pressed about the night of the theft. "I — I was at my post. I was. I was tired. The brazier was warm. I — yes. Yes, I slept. I slept and a monster walked past me with our weapons. There. Are you happy?"

When accused of being the traitor. "I — what? No. No! I — gods help me, I wish I were that important. I am a man who fell asleep. That is all I am. That is all I have been for some time."

If defended by a PC. "...thank you. Thank you. I have been wanting to say that — I saw Edra leaving the village at strange hours this week. Twice. I assumed she was on watch. But she was already off watch. ... Does that mean anything?"

Nim Rattlepot

Role Young trapper. First witness. Pure comic relief.

Wants His boots back. The owlbear took them.

Knows Saw the owlbear wearing a glowing mantle. Heard it speak Common, badly.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
13 (+1)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)

Roleplay note. Speaks too fast when nervous. Insists the owlbear used the word 'unacceptable' three times. May or may not have wet himself during the encounter — won't confirm.

Opening line. "It looked me dead in the eye and said, 'Your village has unacceptable perimeter discipline.' Then it stole my boots."

If asked what the owlbear sounded like. "Like a — like a really polite landslide. Words came out, but slow, like it was choosing each one off a shelf. AND IT KNEW MY NAME. Or — wait. No. It said 'you, person.' Same thing, basically."

If offered to come along. "Me? Into the woods? Where it is? No. Absolutely not. I will be inside. I will be specifically inside. Take Bess if you need a hand — she's scarier than I am and she has a hammer."

If the party returns with his boots. (Will weep with joy.) "These are MY BOOTS. These are MY ACTUAL BOOTS. Thank you. I will name a child after each of you. I don't have children. I will FIND children."

Old Cobb

Role Aging hunter. Survivor of a previous attempt on the lair. Map source.

Wants Nothing. He is tired. He will help if asked.

Knows The entrance. The bells. The smoke room. After that, only chirping.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)

Roleplay note. Speaks slowly. Pauses mid-sentence as if listening to something. He has not slept well since the lair.

Opening line (delivering map). "I saw the front. I saw the smoke. After the smoke I don't remember anything except chirping. Like little birds. But bigger."

If asked about the chirping. "Three of them. Maybe. The sound was… wet. Hungry. Not angry. Hungry. I think about it most nights."

If asked about Edra. (Long pause.) "Edra was on patrol the night I went out. She wasn't on patrol. I saw her boots in the mud by the south road. Edra doesn't take the south road on patrol. I — I never said anything. Should I have said something?"

If thanked for the map. "Don't thank me. I left a man in there. Tomas Vell. I left him because I could not carry him. The eggs were chirping. I ran. … Tell Edra I'm sorry, would you?"

DM Note. Cobb is the one who can break the case wide open if the party asks the right question. He is also unknowingly carrying the news that Tomas — Edra's brother — died three months ago, in the woods, not at raider hands. Edra does not know this yet.

Watch Captain Edra Vell (the traitor)

Role Village watch captain. Tactical ally. Real betrayer.

Wants Her brother Tomas back. (He is already dead. She does not know.)

Will Help the party prep defenses. Suggest the south gate as 'weak.' Volunteer for the gate herself. Hesitate at a critical moment.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	13 (+1)	13 (+1)

Stat block reference. Use Veteran (MM p.350). HP 58, AC 17 (chain mail). Longsword +5 (1d8+3), longbow +4 (1d8+2). Multiattack 2 longsword or 2 longbow.

Description. Mid-thirties. Iron-grey hair, premature. A pale scar runs from her left cheekbone to her jaw — three months old. Walks with a faint limp she hides when she notices anyone watching. Mail kept obsessively clean.

Roleplay note. Plays her as the most useful person in the village. Have her give the party real, good tactical advice. The betrayal should hurt because she actually helped.

Opening line. "Captain Vell. I run the watch — what passes for one. Mayor said you're here for the items. Good. Tell me what you need from me and I'll have it ready before you ride out."

If asked where the raiders will hit. (Slightly too confident.) "South gate. It's the weak point — narrow, low, the watch tower there hasn't been repaired since spring. If I were them, that's where I'd come."

If asked about her scar. (Touches it without thinking.) "Last raid. Three months back. I was lucky. My brother wasn't — they took him. I don't talk about it."

If asked about Tomas (her brother). "He's alive. I know he is. Don't — don't ask me how I know. He's alive."

When confronted with evidence (private). (Long silence. Then she sits down. She does not draw her sword.) "...how long have you known? Was it the boots? The map? Both?" (A pause.) "He sent me a letter. Tomas. Wrapped around his ring. They said if I told them when and where — he lives. So I told them. Once. Then twice. Then every week. The shaman writes the letters. The handwriting is Tomas's. I would know it anywhere. ...He IS alive. He has to be."

When told Tomas is dead (by Cobb or evidence). (She does not speak. She removes her cloak, folds it, lays it on the ground. Picks up her sword. Looks at the party.) "Then I have nothing left to lose. Tell me where to die. I will die useful."

When confronted publicly. (She will draw, but not to fight — to flee. Athletics or Acrobatics chase. If caught, she does not resist. If she escapes, she becomes campaign hook material.)

Bess Tinder

Role Village smith. Practical. The Watson figure who can help the party spot inconsistencies.

Wants To be left alone but secretly enjoys being needed.

Will Repair gear (free). Identify the function of recovered magic items (free). Train villagers (+1 Defense if asked). Watch Edra suspiciously.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)

Description. Late forties. Hands like ham hocks. Eyes that miss nothing. Permanently smudged with soot. Will sometimes lean on her hammer for emphasis.

Roleplay note. Suspicious of authority. Speaks in short bursts. The kind of NPC who notices what everyone else misses but doesn't volunteer it unless asked.

Opening line. "You're the help. Show me what you've got and I'll tell you what it's missing." (Holds out her hand for weapons. She is judging the entire party in five seconds and you can see it.)

If asked about Halven. "Halven? Halven's a sad old man who drinks too much and prays too loud. He didn't do this. Look elsewhere."

If asked about Edra (CLUE). (Long look. Wipes her hands.) "Edra used to laugh more. Something's eating her. Could be the brother. Could be something else. I don't know. I just know she stopped laughing about three months ago, and she's been on the south road a lot at hours that aren't watch hours. …You didn't hear that from me."

If asked to identify an item. (Takes it. Turns it in her hands. Closes her eyes.) "This is a [item]. It does [function]. It's been used recently — within a week. The grip's warm. …That mean anything to you?"

If asked to train villagers. "I can teach a turnip to swing a spear in four hours. Get me a turnip and four hours. Or six villagers. Same thing." (+1 Defense Point.)

When the truth comes out. "…I knew. I didn't KNOW-knew. But I knew. Should've said something. Damn it."

Scene: The Armory Crime Scene

The shrine-armory is a small stone outbuilding behind the chapel. The door has been opened, not broken. Inside, the shelves are nearly empty. Wooden labels lie scattered on the floor.

Clues — let them choose what to roll

Check	DC	Reveals
Investigation	12	Lock picked, not forced. Whoever did it knew how to work tumblers.
Survival	10	Owlbear tracks. Standard depth. Standard claw spread. Headed northwest.
Arcana	13	Faint residue of Intellect-school enchantment near the empty shelf where the village cataloged reports about the missing Mantle.
Perception	14	Charcoal writing on the back wall: 'YOUR INVENTORY SYSTEM WAS UNACCEPTABLE.'
Perception	16	A second note, smaller: 'I have catalogued your deficiencies. Refer to attached.' (No attachment is visible.)
Insight (on Halven)	12	He fell asleep at his post. He knows. He won't say it unless asked directly.

Check	DC	Reveals
Investigation	16	TRAITOR CLUE — Two sets of tracks leaving the armory. One owlbear. One human-sized, with a boot tread matching village watch issue. Headed south, not northwest.
Survival	15	TRAITOR CLUE — The human tracks circle back to the village. Whoever wore those boots came in through the south wall, not the gate.
History or Arcana	13	The Mantle of Intellect was not village-made. It matches the silver-violet mantle worn by Ilyra Voss, a missing scholar-adventurer last seen heading into the Western Woods three months ago.

Don't volunteer the traitor clues

If the players don't ask to investigate further, don't offer DC 15+ rolls. The clues are there for thorough parties; less thorough parties will learn the truth during the battle itself. Both paths work.

If the party tries to skip the village

Let them — but they lose the chance to organize the defense. Their starting Village Defense Points drop from 3 to 1 (see Final Battle). Make this consequence visible: Tessa says, '...so you're just leaving us, then,' and lets them go.

Act 2 — The Western Woods

Two hours into the forest, the trees thicken. Birdsong stops. The tracks remain consistent but begin to deviate — sometimes doubling back, sometimes leading to obvious ambush points the party can avoid by simply not following them.

The Warning Signs

Three wooden boards nailed to trees along the approach. Show all three. They are getting more articulate.

Sign 1: "TURN BACK. THIS IS NOT A REQUEST."

Sign 2: "I HAVE READ TWO BOOKS ON SIEGE WARFARE."

Sign 3: "I AM PREPARED TO DEFEND MY RIGHTS, AS UNDERSTOOD BY ME, GRUBBLECLAW, ACTING MAGISTRATE OF THESE WOODS."

Encounter: Log Swing Trap

Spot	Perception DC 14 to notice the trip line
Trigger	Trip line, 15 ft before a large hanging log
Save	Dexterity DC 14 or take 3d6 bludgeoning damage and be knocked prone

Detail	On the log, scratched into the bark: 'EXHIBIT A.'
After	Whether sprung or avoided, the party is now visible to the lair's first watchpost

Encounter: Skitters, the Captured Goblin Scout

Hanging upside down from a tree by his ankle. Alive. Annoyed. Has been there since dawn.

What Skitters tells the party — for free

- The Red Tusk Raiders arrive by nightfall. He was sent ahead.
- Their target is the village, but "also the eggs." (He won't elaborate unless pressed.)
- He was caught because the bear-bird asked him "excellent follow-up questions" and he panicked.
- The shaman with the warband is very interested in "smart owlbear babies."

What Skitters tells the party — if cut down or bribed

- Raider numbers (see Final Battle roster).
- Their plan is a feint at the front gate while a strike team breaks for the lair.
- He'll join the party if treated reasonably. Loyal until he sees a better offer.
- TRAITOR CLUE — If asked how the raiders know so much about Brindlebarrow's defenses: 'The iron-haired one with the scar. She told us where to hit. South gate. The shaman writes her letters every week. I deliver some of them.'
- If pressed further on the iron-haired woman: 'Don't know her name. Tall. Has a limp she hides. Brings information, takes letters back. Always at the south road, never the north.'

Skitters's favorite line: "The bear-bird made me explain our chain of command. I don't even know our chain of command!"

If asked why he's being so helpful: "Look. The bear-bird scared me. The shaman scares me MORE. You have not yet scared me, but you have not killed me, which is more than either of them can say. I am voting for you with my mouth."

Act 3 — The Lair

Tone shift

The forest signs are funny. The lair is not. Once the party crosses the barricade, the comedy stays as character voice — but the stakes get real. Grubbleclaw is genuinely dangerous and genuinely afraid. Play the fear underneath the bluster.

Area 1 — Entrance Barricade

The cave mouth has been narrowed with a crude wooden barricade. Two bells on strings hang at chest height. A wooden sign reads: "AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY. ALSO FISH DELIVERIES."

- Stealth DC 14 group check to get past the bells without ringing them. Failure = Grubbleclaw is alerted.
- If bells ring: the smoke chamber activates 1 round later.

Area 2 — Smoke Chamber

> *The tunnel opens into a broad chamber filled with curling green-grey smoke. Visibility ends at five feet. Somewhere in the murk, something heavy shifts.*

The Eversmoking Bottle is wedged into a crack in the ceiling. Heavily obscured throughout.

- Sight checks at disadvantage. Ranged attacks at disadvantage.
- Investigation DC 13 to spot the bottle. An action to retrieve and stopper it clears the smoke over 2 rounds.
- Grubbleclaw may make one hit-and-run pass here if the party triggered the bells. Single attack, then retreat to Area 3. Not lethal force — it is testing them.

Area 3 — Tactical Testing Ground

> *A wider chamber. Javelins protrude from straw targets. A patch of dried web clings to the far wall. On a flat rock, someone has scratched a detailed map of Brindlebarrow into the stone, with small carved figurines arranged across it.*

This room is the proof that Grubbleclaw is real. The party should leave it certain they are dealing with a strategist.

- **Investigation DC 12:** The figurines are arranged in a defensive formation against an attack from the south — the same direction the raiders are coming from.
- **Investigation DC 14:** A piece of charcoal-on-bark note reads: 'Village defense collapses in 3.5 minutes without choke points. Recommend Western Bridge, Mill Wall, Chapel.'
- **Arcana DC 14:** The web patch is dried Wand of Web residue — the wand has been fired here, multiple times, in practice.
- **Investigation DC 14 (TRAITOR CLUE):** The arrows on the village map show every approach as a guess — except the south gate, drawn with confident precision. Whoever knows the south gate that well knows the village from the inside. Grubbleclaw drew this map from intel it overheard or intercepted. The owlbear has scratched a tiny note beside the south arrow: 'WHY DOES ONE LINE KNOW MORE THAN THE OTHERS? INVESTIGATE.'

Investigation or Arcana DC 13: A water-stained spellbook lies open beside claw-scratched notes. The name inside the cover reads Ilyra Voss. The notes suggest Grubbleclaw learned language and strategy from the dead scholar’s books after the Mantle awakened.

Area 4 — The Negotiation Chamber

> *The tunnel widens into a circular chamber lit by a glowing orb hanging from the ceiling. A flat stone slab dominates the center. On one side: three rough stools, hand-carved, sized for humans. On the other: a single enormous log, polished where something has been sitting on it.*

On the log sits the owlbear. It wears a silver-violet mantle strapped beneath its neck feathers. Its beak is closed. Its eyes are open.

"You may present your claim to the arms," it says, in Common, slowly, as if testing each word. "Speak clearly. I dislike mumbling."

This is the centerpiece of the session

Do not rush it. Do not roll initiative the moment they enter. Grubbleclaw genuinely wants to negotiate — it has been preparing this speech for two weeks.

If the players attack on sight, that's their call. But describe Grubbleclaw lowering itself slowly into a defensive crouch, sword-arm shields raised in its beak, and saying, 'Disappointing. I had prepared an opening statement.' Then run combat per the stat block.

Grubbleclaw's opening statement

"When I was stupid, you called me a monster. Now I can reason, speak, plan, and defend my territory. Yet you still call me a monster.

Tell me, little sword-people: at what exact number of thoughts does a creature become a person? Five? Fifty? Five hundred? Do you count them yourselves, or has someone counted them for you?

I will hear your arguments. But understand: the items remain here because your village cannot protect them. I am not a thief. I am a more responsible custodian."

Grubbleclaw Dialogue Bank

Pick the response that matches the approach. Several variants per tactic so you can swap during a long scene.

If a PC tries intimidation:

- "You believe yourselves frightening. I have hunted things that screamed in seven languages. You manage one. Poorly."
- "Threats are arguments without evidence. I require evidence."
- (To a small or persuasion-heavy character intimidating) "The smaller the speaker, the larger the threat. I have noticed this pattern in the books."

If a PC tries deception (not yet caught):

- "Continue. I find your reasoning… informative."
- (Tilts head.) "Go on. Use more words. The more words you use, the more I learn."

If deception is caught (Insight DC 14):

- "Stop. Stop talking. I am not insulted. I am disappointed. I had hoped for honesty."
- "You have wasted the only currency that mattered in this room. Your turn is over."

If a PC tries Animal Handling without respect:

- "Did you… did you just click your tongue at me?"
- (Stands. Slowly.) "I AM NOT A HORSE."

If a PC offers partial return of items:

- "Half. Half is a coward's compromise. But I am a magistrate, and I understand the political utility of compromise. … Half."
- "Which half? I will not have you choosing. I choose. The horn. The globe. The potions. The javelins. The shield and the wand remain."

If a PC proposes full alliance:

- "An alliance. Between a village that called me a monster yesterday and a magistrate who stole their goods. … You realize you are proposing a treaty."
- "Bring me a document. Words spoken vanish. Words signed do not. Bring me a document, and we will speak of alliance."

If a PC proposes a formal compact (History/Arcana DC 13):

- (Clearly excited.) "A compact. Yes. YES — with witnesses. With clauses. With penalties for breach. THIS is how civilized beings disagree."
- "Continue. What else does proper compact-craft require? Speak slowly. I will be writing this down on the wall."

If a PC tells Grubbleclaw it is a person:

- "Do not flatter me. I do not require it. I require the items remain where they are best used."
- (After a pause, quieter.) "…But. Thank you. Few have said it. None have meant it. I will remember the face of the one who said it first."

If a PC mentions the raiders are coming for the EGGS:

- (Long silence.) "Say that again. Slowly. Use the word eggs."
- (After the second telling.) "Then we have a problem. Together. … The shape of this conversation has changed."

If a PC mentions the village has a traitor:

- "A traitor. Inside. That explains the south arrow on my map. I drew that arrow from a goblin's mumbling, not my own intelligence. Tell me — who is your traitor?"
- (If the party doesn't know yet.) "Then go and learn. I will hold the items. I will hold the eggs. Return when you know your own house."

If a PC asks how it got the Mantle:
"It was on a dead one. I did not kill her for the mantle. I killed her because she entered the nest-path with fire in her hand. The mantle was… accidental. At first."
"Her name was Ilyra Voss. I know this because she wrote it inside every book. Humans put their names on things, then complain when others claim property."
"The mantle is not your village's property. The arms are disputed. The mantle is not."

Combat banter (call out one per round, max):

- (Round 1, Wand of Web missed.) "THIS WAND IS DESIGNED FOR FINGERS."
- (Hits a heavy-armored target.) "ARMOR DOES NOT PROTECT FROM ARGUMENTS!"
- (A PC frees a webbed ally.) "HOLD STILL. I AM AIMING."
- (Below half HP, alliance still possible.) "WE ARE BOTH BLEEDING. THIS IS UNPRODUCTIVE."
- (If a PC says "magistrate" mid-combat.) "…we can stop. We can stop right now. SAY IT AGAIN."

Discovering the eggs scene — alternates to the existing line:

- (Quiet.) "I had hoped to negotiate before this."
- "Now you see why I cannot lose."

- "They are not weapons. They are not property. They are mine."

Post-victory together (if alliance ending):

- "Your tactics were… acceptable. The screaming was excessive but motivating."
- "I have decided your village is no longer 'unacceptable.' Merely 'concerning.' Progress."
- "Tell the mayor I will require a desk. A large one. Bring books."

Signing the Accord:

- "Bring it forward. I will sign with my own claw — there can be no dispute."
- (When asked what name to write.) "Magistrate Grubbleclaw. Capital M. Capital G. Both."

Looking at the hatched cub:

- (Cub bites a PC's boot.) "Promising. Already testing boundaries."
- (Quietly, after a pause.) "They will not need magic to think. I will teach them."

Negotiation mechanics

Do not gate this behind a single Persuasion roll. Let the players build a case across multiple beats. Each strong argument or piece of evidence lowers the next DC by 1 (cumulative, no floor below 8).

Approach	DC	Result
Persuasion — return some items	15	Returns Horn, Driftglobe, potion crate. Keeps Wand, Shield, Mantle.
Persuasion — full alliance	18	Helps defend village. Keeps Mantle + one defensive item.
Intimidation	17	Returns most items but refuses alliance. Tense departure. May ambush them later if it survives.
Deception (must specify lie)	15	If caught (Insight 14), combat starts at disadvantage for the lying PC.
Animal Handling	16	Only works if paired with respectful framing. Fails automatically if anyone says 'beast.'
History / Arcana — formal compact	13	Lowers Persuasion DC by 3 for next attempt. Grubbleclaw loves legal structure.

Things that automatically anger Grubbleclaw

- Calling it 'beast,' 'animal,' or 'creature.'
- Pointing weapons during conversation.
- Interrupting it.
- Suggesting the mantle 'belongs' to the village.
- Mentioning Brother Halven's name without using his title.

Things that disarm it

- Addressing it as 'Magistrate.'
- Asking what it has read.

Approach	DC	Result
• Acknowledging that the village armory was poorly defended. • Offering it books or legal documents. • Mentioning the incoming raiders before it has to.		

The Eggs — The Reveal

This beat fires when one of the following happens:

- A player rolls 18+ on Insight while talking to Grubbleclaw.
- A player asks why it stole the items in the first place.
- Combat reduces Grubbleclaw below half HP and someone calls for a parley.
- A player goes deeper into the cave without permission and discovers Area 5.

Area 5 — The Nest

The tunnel behind the negotiation chamber bends once, then opens.

The room is not a hoard. Shields lean against the walls in overlapping layers. A glowing globe hangs from a rope, casting soft blue light over a nest of branches, moss, and torn village banners. A sentinel-shape shield faces the entrance, propped on a rock. A wand rests on a flat stone within reach.

In the center of the nest are three enormous speckled eggs. One rocks gently. The smallest has a faint crack running down its side.

Behind you, the owlbear lowers its wand.

"Do not come closer," it says.

Its voice, this time, is not proud. It is afraid.

Play the silence

Don't fill the room with description. Let the players process. If they make jokes, let the jokes land — then describe the cracked egg again, quietly.

Grubbleclaw's revised demands

Once the eggs are seen, Grubbleclaw drops the magistrate persona and asks for what it actually wants:

- Protection for the eggs.
- A promise the hatchlings will not be hunted.
- No villagers near the nest without permission.

- The right to keep one defensive item until the eggs hatch.
- Books on parenting, law, and siege defense.

Optional line: "Also, a midwife. Or whatever the egg version of that is."

The new question

Spell it out to yourself, not the players

The party now has three competing truths. The village needs the items. The owlbear stole them. The owlbear's eggs will die without protection.

The best outcome is no longer 'return everything.' It's a shared defense pact. Watch for the moment a player figures this out — that's when the session pivots from comedy to commitment.

Combat — If It Happens

Grubbleclaw is scaled as a CR 7 solo threat for 5 level-6 PCs. It will not fight to the death unless protecting the eggs.

MAGISTRATE GRUBBLECLAW

Large monstrosity (with Mantle of Intellect)
Armor Class 16 (natural armor + Sentinel Shield held in beak)
Hit Points 142 (15d10 + 60)
Speed 40 ft.
Saving Throws Str +7, Wis +4
Skills Perception +6, Insight +4, Investigation +4
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 16
Languages Common (slow, formal), understands Sylvan
Challenge 7 (2,900 XP)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	12 (+1)	18 (+4)	19 (+4)	13 (+1)	13 (+1)

TRAITS

Keen Sight and Smell. Advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on sight or smell.

Mantle of Intellect. INT is 19 while worn. The mantle is strapped beneath Grubbleclaw's neck feathers. Removing it requires Grubbleclaw to be restrained or grappled, then a full action and a successful DC 16 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check. Failure alerts and enrages Grubbleclaw. It defends the mantle as fiercely as the eggs.

Tactical Mind. Once per round, Grubbleclaw can take the Disengage, Dodge, or Help action as a bonus action.

Parental Fury. While within 30 ft. of its eggs, attacks against creatures threatening the nest are made with advantage and deal +1d6 damage on hit.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Grubbleclaw makes two attacks: one with its beak and one with its claws.

Beak. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 10 (1d10 + 5) piercing damage.

Claws. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 14 (2d8 + 5) slashing damage.

Wand of Web (3/Long Rest). Action. 15-ft. radius sphere, range 60 ft. DC 13 Dex save or restrained. Heavily obscured. Awkward beak grip imposes disadvantage on the wand's targeting — if the save is failed, also roll 1d4: on a 1, Grubbleclaw webs itself instead. Play this for laughs the first time. The second time it works.

Returning Javelin (x3). Ranged Weapon Attack with disadvantage (motor skills): +6 to hit, range 30/120 ft. Hit: 7 (1d6 + 4) piercing damage. Javelin returns to its claw at end of turn.

Eversmoking Bottle (1/encounter). Action. Releases 30-ft. radius of smoke (heavily obscured) centered on Grubbleclaw. Lasts 1 minute or until stoppered.

TACTICS

Opening round. Wand of Web on the densest cluster of PCs. If they're spread, switch to a single high-threat target (the heavy hitter, not the caster — it underestimates spellcasters).

Round 2. Charge the most-armored target. Multiattack. Grubbleclaw believes armor means seriousness.

Round 3+. Use Tactical Mind to Disengage and reposition behind cover. Fire returning javelins. Loudly declare its battle doctrine: 'I HAVE STUDIED YOUR BATTLE DOCTRINE AND FOUND IT MOSTLY STABBING!'

Below half HP. If eggs are not in immediate danger, attempts parley: 'WAIT! IF YOU KILL ME, WHO DEFENDS THE WESTERN RIDGE?' If eggs are threatened, fights to the death.

Below 30 HP. Retreats to nest. Stands over eggs. Will not attack anyone who stops advancing.

Act 4 — The Final Defense

Dusk. Drums. The raiders arrive on schedule. This battle runs on two fronts simultaneously — and somewhere in the village, a third quiet front opens: the traitor makes her move.

The Betrayal — When and How It Reveals

Edra's reveal has four possible timings. Use whichever the party's investigation has earned.

Timing 1 — Pre-battle confrontation (private)

If the party has gathered two or more traitor clues and approaches Edra privately before sundown.

> *(She is sharpening her sword by the well. She looks up. Her face does not change.)*
>
> *"...how long have you known? Was it the boots? The map? Both?"*
>
> *(A pause. She sets the sword down. She does not draw it.)*

"He sent me a letter. Tomas. Wrapped around his ring. They said if I told them when and where — he lives. So I told them. Once. Then twice. Then every week. The shaman writes the letters. The handwriting is Tomas's. I would know it anywhere."

"...He IS alive. He has to be. Tell me he's alive."

Timing 2 — Pre-battle confrontation (public)

If a PC accuses Edra in front of Tessa or in the square.

- Edra will draw and run, not fight. She is sprinting for the south gate to surrender to the raiders before they kill her.
- Athletics or Acrobatics chase (DC 14). Each PC gets one attempt.
- If caught: she does not resist. She kneels. Skip to her interrogation.
- If she escapes: she reaches the raider lines. She returns in the final battle, on their side, fighting beside the bugbear chief. Use Veteran stats.

Timing 3 — Cobb breaks the news

If the party brings Edra and Cobb into the same room (or asks Cobb directly about Tomas):

(Cobb is staring at his hands. He cannot look up.)

"Edra. Edra, I have to. Tomas didn't make it out of the camp. He was already gone when I crawled past. I left his body because I could not carry it. I thought — I thought someone else would tell you. I thought it was my place to tell you. I never did."

(Edra does not speak. She looks at Cobb for a very long time.)

(Then she looks at her own hands.)

"...three months. I have been killing my village for a corpse's ring."

Timing 4 — Mid-battle reveal (no investigation)

If the party skipped or missed every traitor clue, this fires automatically during the village defense.

- Round 3 of the Front A battle: Edra is holding the south gate. The party will see her step BACK from the line at a critical moment, opening a hole. Insight DC 13 to recognize the hesitation as deliberate (not panic).
- Round 4: a raider yells past her, 'WHERE IS OUR INSIDE WOMAN?' Edra does not respond. The implication will land.
- If a PC engages her directly, she will fight defensively (Dodge action) and try to surrender if reduced below half HP.

Edra's Choices — What the Party Does With Her

Once revealed, the table can choose:

- **Execute her:** Some parties will. Don't argue. Tessa will weep but will not stop them. Subtract 1 Village Defense Point — morale damage.
- **Imprison her:** Tessa's preferred outcome. She will face village justice after the battle. No Defense Point change.
- **Let her redeem herself:** If she fights for the village, she will die in the battle. She wants this. +1 Defense Point during the fight. Have her line: 'Tell my mayor I was useful at the end.'
- **Let her flee:** She vanishes into the woods. The party may encounter her later as a campaign hook — broken, hunted by both sides.

DM note — keep it under five minutes

The traitor reveal is a strong scene but it is not the centerpiece of the session. Don't let it eat the negotiation chamber's time. If the party wants to spend forty minutes on the reveal, gently push them: 'Drums. The raiders are at the tree line.' The traitor subplot exists to sharpen the village battle, not replace it.

The Two Fronts

Front A — The Village Gate

Main assault. Frontal pressure. Bodies and noise.

Unit	Count	Source
Goblin	10	MM p.166
Hobgoblin	6	MM p.186
Hobgoblin Captain	1	MM p.187
Ogre	2	MM p.237
Bugbear Chief	1	VGtM p.119 or MM Bugbear reflavored

Front B — The Egg Raid

Triggers at the start of Round 3 of the village battle. A scouting party breaks west toward the lair while everyone is engaged at the gate.

Unit	Count	Source
Goblin Scout (use Goblin stats, +stealth)	3	MM p.166
Hobgoblin	2	MM p.186
Bugbear	1	MM p.33 — the 'egg-snatcher'
Red Tusk Shaman	1	Use Acolyte +1 spell slot, Animal Friendship, Cure Wounds, Bless

Unit	Count	Source
Total XP target Front A and Front B combined ≈ 8,400 XP (raw, before multiplier). For 5 level-6 PCs, this lands at the hard-to-deadly border with the multiplier for large enemy groups applied. They should sweat. They should not all die. If you need a brake: the bugbear chief flees at 25% HP, taking the remaining goblins with him. If you need a gas pedal: the shaman casts Bless on the bugbear egg-snatcher at the start of Round 2.		

The Egg-Raid Decision

At the start of Round 3, the party hears Skitters (if alive) or a village kid shout that figures are breaking west. The party now has to choose:

- Defend the village (lose the eggs unless Grubbleclaw is fighting at the nest).
- Defend the eggs (village takes additional Defense Point damage each round they're absent).
- Split the party (both fights run, but each fight is now harder by one tier).
- Convince Grubbleclaw to defend the nest while they defend the gate (alliance ending).
- Move the eggs into the village chapel (requires negotiation — Grubbleclaw must agree).

If they move the eggs to the village

Both fights consolidate at the gate. Grubbleclaw fights alongside the party. This is the best ending and the players have earned it — don't pull punches but don't punish them with bad luck either. Let them feel competent.

Village Defense Points

Don't run thirty villagers individually. Track village survival as a pool.

Starting value: 3

Condition	Adjustment
Horn of Warning recovered before dusk	+1
Wand of Web recovered before dusk	+1
Sentinel Shield recovered before dusk	+1
Healing potions recovered before dusk	+1
Driftglobe / Quiver / Smoke Bottle (each)	+0 (cosmetic, color the fight)
Players trained villagers (1 hour spent)	+1
Bess Tinder trains villagers (1 hour, free)	+1
Players set traps at gate/bridge (1 hour spent)	+1

Condition	Adjustment
Grubbleclaw fights for the village	+2
Eggs moved to chapel safely	+1 (Grubbleclaw fights harder)
Edra revealed pre-battle (no surprise hole at south gate)	+1
Edra redeems herself in battle	+1 (she dies fighting)
Edra escapes to raider lines	−1 (fights against village)
Edra publicly executed pre-battle	−1 (morale damage)
Party skipped Act 1 entirely	−2

During the raid, at the end of each round of village combat where raiders remain active, reduce Village Defense by 1. If it hits 0, narrate buildings burning, villagers falling — and the village survives but is wounded. If it ends the battle at 3+, the village is essentially intact. If it ends at 5+, no villagers died and Tessa names a tavern after the party.

Endings

The Best Ending — The Brindlebarrow Nest Accord

Owlbear helps defend the village. Raiders are routed. The village reluctantly signs a treaty recognizing Grubbleclaw as 'Provisional Forest Marshal and Emergency Bearer of Arms.'

- Reward: 500 gp split among the party, one uncommon magic item of the DM's choice, Grubbleclaw's Writ of Passage (see handouts).
- After the battle, the cracked egg hatches. The cub immediately bites a PC's boot.
- Grubbleclaw's line: "Promising. Already testing boundaries."

The Violent Ending — Mantle Removed

Party defeats Grubbleclaw, removes the mantle, returns the items. Grubbleclaw is now a normal owlbear standing over three eggs.

- Village is saved.
- Reward: 500 gp, one uncommon magic item, but no Writ.
- The eggs are still there. The village now has to decide what to do with them. That decision happens off-camera unless the party stays.
- This ending should feel like a win that costs something. Don't punish the players, but don't gloss it either.

The Bad Ending — Items Recovered Too Late

Party gets the items but failed to organize the village. Village Defense Points start low and collapse. Raiders damage the village significantly before being driven off.

- Reward: 300 gp. Tessa is curt at payment.

- Bittersweet — still playable. The village survives but is wounded. Some named NPCs may have died (DM's call).

The Chaotic Ending — Owlbear Keeps Everything

Party sides with Grubbleclaw completely. Items stay in the lair. Owlbear crushes the raiders.

- Village is furious. The party is no longer welcome in Brindlebarrow.
- Reward: Grubbleclaw's protection in the Western Woods. No gold.
- Campaign fuel: the region now has a heavily armed, legalistic, intelligent owlbear with three hatchlings on the way.

Traitor Aftermath — Regardless of Main Ending

Edra's fate runs in parallel to the main resolution. Use whichever fits how she ended the battle:

If she was executed pre-battle:

- Tessa attends the burial but does not speak at it. Bess says, 'She wasn't wrong about everything. Doesn't matter now.'
- The village is quieter for a year. No songs are sung at the autumn festival.

If she was imprisoned:

- Village trial three days after the battle. Sentence: ten years of public labor — repairing the wall she helped breach.
- She will accept it without speaking. Cobb visits her every week. Neither of them speaks much.

If she died redeeming herself:

- Buried with watch honors. Tessa's eulogy: 'She did one terrible thing for one good reason. That is most of us, on our worst day.'
- Bonus reward: the party finds Tomas's pinky ring among Edra's effects. They can return it to Cobb, who will weep for the first time since the woods.

If she escaped:

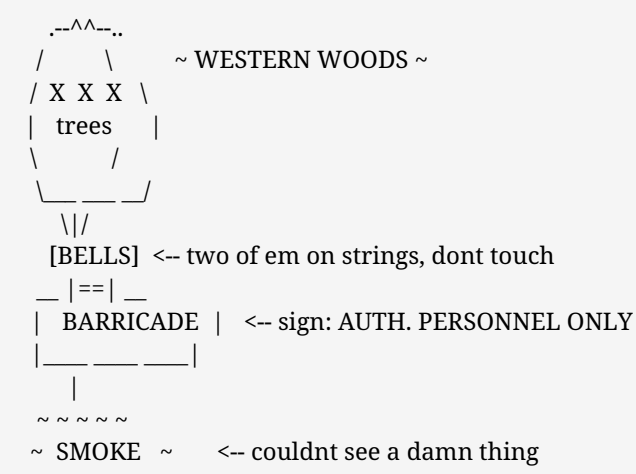
- Campaign hook. She is alive somewhere, neither raider nor villager. The Red Tusk shaman will hunt her. So will Brindlebarrow.
- Useful future plot: a hooded figure leaves an anonymous warning at the gate three months later, signed only 'E.'

Player Handout 1 — The Survivor's Map

Hand this to the party when they meet Old Cobb in Brindlebarrow — an aging hunter who tried to recover the items two days ago, was webbed at the cave mouth, knocked out, and dragged half-conscious to where he eventually crawled out. His memory of the lair is partial and the map gets less reliable the deeper it goes.

Old Cobb's actual line when delivering the map: "I saw the front. I saw the smoke. After the smoke I don't remember anything except chirping. Like little birds. But bigger."

OLD COBB'S MAP (scratched on a piece of bark, charcoal smudges throughout)



DM Note (do not show players)

The map confirms: (1) the bells exist, (2) there is smoke in the second room, (3) something with the word 'chirping' is deeper in. Players who connect 'chirping' + 'bigger than birds' + 'owlbear stealing things' may suspect eggs early. That's fine — it doesn't break the reveal, it makes them feel smart.

Player Handout 2 — The Brindlebarrow Nest Accord

Hand this to the party only if they negotiate the best ending. Grubbleclaw insists on writing it. It is signed with a claw print.

THE BRINDLEBARROW NEST ACCORD

AND MUTUAL DEFENSE COMPACT

By the authority of MAGISTRATE GRUBBLECLAW, Sovereign Defender of the Western Woods,

Bearer of Arms, and Acting Minister of Strategic Security; and by consent of the VILLAGE OF BRINDLEBARROW, represented by Mayor Tessa Wicker:

ARTICLE I.

The Village shall not hunt, trap, or trespass within the nesting grounds of the Western Ridge without explicit permission of the Magistrate.

ARTICLE II.

The Magistrate shall return the following items to the Village armory: the Horn of Warning, the Quiver of Returning Javelins, the Driftglobe, the Eversmoking Bottle, and the Potion Crate (full).

ARTICLE III.

The Magistrate shall retain custody of the Sentinel Shield and Wand of Web for the defense of the nest, to be reviewed when the eggs have hatched and the cubs are independent.

ARTICLE IV.

The Mantle of Intellect shall remain with the Magistrate in perpetuity. This article is non-negotiable.

ARTICLE V.

The Magistrate shall provide defense of Brindlebarrow against external threats when summoned by three blasts of the Horn of Warning, provided such threats do not require absence from the nest exceeding one (1) day.

ARTICLE VI.

No villager, traveler, or scholar shall refer to the Magistrate as 'animal,' 'beast,' or 'creature' in formal or informal speech. Violation: a fine of one book, paid to the Magistrate's library.

ARTICLE VII.

The Village shall deliver to the Magistrate, monthly: six (6) fresh fish; two (2) books on subjects of the Magistrate's choosing; one (1) report on village security.

Signed this day in the soil of the Western Ridge,

_____ _____

Magistrate Grubbleclaw Mayor Tessa Wicker

(claw print) *(signature)*

Player Handout 3 — The Writ of Passage

Given to the party at the conclusion of the best ending. A small piece of birch bark, scratched in awkward but careful Common.

WRIT OF PASSAGE

issued by

MAGISTRATE GRUBBLECLAW

Sovereign Defender of the Western Woods

Let it be known to all woods-folk,

creatures with teeth, creatures without,

and creatures who do not yet know which:

These travelers are not to be eaten

unless they become unreasonable.

— G.

(claw print)

Final Continuity Locks
Mantle of Intellect: originally belonged to Ilyra Voss, not the village. Grubbleclaw got it after the scholar died in the nesting grounds.
Tomas Vell: dead before the session begins. The Red Tusk shaman used his ring and forged letters to control Edra.
Grubbleclaw: not allied with the horde. It is defending the fortified area and the eggs against the same threat.
Player handouts: never reveal eggs, nest, Edra's guilt, Halven's innocence, Tomas's death, or the raiders' egg objective before play earns it.

DM Cheat Sheet — Keep This Beside You

These final reference pages combine the adventure-specific numbers with first-time-DM rescue moves. Once you know the story, you should be able to run most of the session from this section.

New DM emergency moves

When this happens	Do this
Players are stuck	Restate the obvious facts and name two or three leads they already earned. Do not make them guess the one answer in your head.
They miss or ignore a clue	Move the information forward through another NPC, a visible consequence, or the next location. Preserve the discovery; not the exact delivery method.
A rules argument starts	Hear the question, make one table ruling, note it, and continue. Revisit the rule after the session unless the ruling would immediately decide life or death.
They solve something cleverly	Let the clever plan work if it is plausible. Good play is not a problem you need to correct.
The party is in serious trouble	Telegraph danger and give meaningful outs: retreat, surrender, bargain, cover, rescue, or a changed objective. Keep consequences, but do not hide the exits.
You lose your place	Call a five-minute break. Re-read the current scene's Wants/Knows/Tactics and the 'If you only remember three things' section, then resume.

For an action not listed below, start with DC 10 / 15 / 20 for easy / medium / hard. Lower the DC—or skip the roll—when a smart plan, correct tool, or good preparation removes most of the uncertainty.

All DCs in one place

Where	Check	DC
Armory	Investigation (lock picked)	12
Armory	Survival (tracks)	10
Armory	Arcana (intellect residue)	13
Armory	Perception (wall note 1)	14
Armory	Perception (wall note 2)	16
Armory	Insight on Halven	12
Armory	Investigation (2nd tracks — TRAITOR)	16
Armory	Survival (boot trail south — TRAITOR)	15
Forest	Perception (trip line)	14
Forest	Dex save (log trap)	14
Lair	Stealth (bells)	14
Lair	Investigation (smoke bottle)	13
Lair	Investigation (battle map)	12
Lair	Investigation (south arrow — TRAITOR)	14
Lair	Investigation (defense note)	14

Where	Check	DC
Lair	Arcana (web residue)	14
Negotiation	Persuasion (partial return)	15
Negotiation	Persuasion (alliance)	18
Negotiation	Intimidation (return only)	17
Negotiation	Deception	15 / Insight 14
Negotiation	Animal Handling	16
Negotiation	History/Arcana (compact)	13
Reveal	Insight (Grubbleclaw is hiding something)	18
Battle	Insight (Edra's hesitation deliberate)	13
Battle	Athletics/Acrobatics (catching Edra)	14
Armory	History/Arcana (Mantle origin)	13

Grubbleclaw at a glance

HP / AC	142 / 16
Speed	40 ft.
Attacks	Beak +8 (1d10+5), Claws +8 (2d8+5), or Wand of Web
Wand of Web	3/long rest, DC 13 Dex, awkward (1-in-4 self-web)
Parental Fury	+1d6 damage near nest, advantage on attacks
Tactical Mind	Disengage/Dodge/Help as bonus action
Retreat trigger	Half HP (parley) / 30 HP (returns to nest)

Village Defense quick math

Starting	3
Each major item recovered	+1 each (Horn, Wand, Shield, Potions)
Trained villagers (1 hr)	+1
Set traps (1 hr)	+1
Grubbleclaw fights for village	+2
Eggs moved to chapel	+1

Skipped Act 1	−2
End of each combat round	−1 if raiders still active
Below 0	Village wounded — narrate, don't TPK

Lines worth memorizing

(Spoken in Common, slow, careful, like each word is being chosen from a menu.)

- 'You may present your claim to the arms. Speak clearly. I dislike mumbling.'
- 'At what exact number of thoughts does a creature become a person?'
- 'I HAVE STUDIED YOUR BATTLE DOCTRINE AND FOUND IT MOSTLY STABBING!'
- 'Your village had one lock, no guard rotation, and a priest who naps after lunch.'
- 'Do not come closer.' (when they find the eggs — voice quieter, not louder)
- 'Promising. Already testing boundaries.' (cub bites a PC's boot)

Edra's lines worth memorizing:

- 'South gate. It's the weak point. If I were them, that's where I'd come.' (pre-battle, slightly too confident)
- 'He sent me a letter. Tomas. Wrapped around his ring.'
- 'I have been killing my village for a corpse's ring.'
- 'Tell me where to die. I will die useful.'

If you only remember three things

- 1. The eggs are the heart. Everything else is decoration.
- 2. The negotiation chamber should run 45–60 minutes — protect it from being skipped.
- 3. The traitor subplot is a side dish, not the main course. Five minutes for the reveal, then back to the battle. The session has TWO moral questions stacked — don't lose the first one chasing the second.

New-DM rule: make the world difficult, not the table. Explain what the characters would reasonably understand, invite questions, and never make a player feel foolish for not knowing a rule.